If Life is a Bowl of Cherries, What am I Doing in the Pits?

By Erma Bombeck

Dear Mrs. Bombeck,

I do not understand Mothers.

How come my Mom can hit anyone anywhere in the house at any distance with a shoe?

How can she tell without turning her head in the car that I am making faces at my brother in the back seat?

How can she be watching television in the living room and know that I am sneaking cookies in the kitchen?

We think it is spooky the way the phone rings and before we even pick it up she says, "Five mintues!"

Since you write about kids all the time, we thought you could explain Moms to us.

Sincerely, Cathie

INTRODUCTION

Dear Cathie and children everywhere . . .

Mothers are just normal people, really. We don't pretend to be perfect or to have all the answers to childrearing. Why, throughout the years, there are a lot of aspects of children for which I profess complete ignorance. For example . . .

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Haven't I always loved Whatshisname the best?

A women starts thinking of a name for her baby from the minute she knows she is carrying one. She will write it out, say it aloud, try it out on her friends and embroider it on little shirts. When the baby is born she will whisper the name softly in its ear, write it on dozens of announcements and file in in the courthouse records.

A few years and a few kids later, she can't remember who you are.

I've heard mothers go through ten or twelve names before they get lucky and hit the right one. (Once I wore my P.J.s wrong side out and my mom, thinking it was a name tag, called me Dr. Denton for a week.)

Children seem to think there is something Freudian in the entire exercise. The old if-my-mother-really-loved-me-she'd-remember-my-name trauma. This is hogwash. I love Marc . . . Mary . . . Mike . . . Mil . . . Massa . . whatshisname with the same affection as I love Bet . . . Bronc . . Evely . . . Mar . . . Tri . . . you know who you are.

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Our neighborhood psychiatrist bears me out. He said there is nothing you can generalize from mothers who can't put a name to their children right off the bat.

It used to be a good day for me when I could remember what I called them for, let alone remember who they are.

In talking with a young married [man] the other day, it was revealed that he was one of seven children and not once when he was growing up was he ever called by his real name. "I guess it was because there were so many of us," he said, "that it confused my mother."

I hated to shoot his theory down, but for a long while I was an only child and still got Sara . . Bet . . Mild . . Vir . . Edna. Finally, in desperation, my mother would shout, "How long do I have to call you before you answer?"

I'd yell back, "Until you get it right."

"Was I close?" she'd shout.

"Edna was somewhere in the neighborhood."

"I always like Edna," she mused. "I should have named you that."

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"Then why did you name me Erma?"

"Because it was easy to remember."

At what age is a child capable of dressing himself?

Some say when a child can reach the clothes hamper without falling in, he is ready to assume responsibility for what he wears.

A child develops individuality long before he develops taste. I have seen my kid straggle into the kitchen in the morning with outfits that need only one accessory: an empty gin bottle.

There is always one child in the family who thrives on insecurities and must have her emotional temperature taken every five minutes. I call it the "Parade of the Closet." Beginning at 7 a.m. she will appear at breakfast fully clothed and ready for school. Before the cereal has stopped exploding in the bowl, she has disappeared to her room and is in another complete outfit. Four words from her mother ("You look nice today") and she is off again to her bedroom in tears for still another complete change.

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She plays the same musical clothes until she runs out of clothes/the bus leaves/her mother is instutionalized . . . whichever ever comes first.

There is always the kid who has an aversion to clean clothes. He is allergic to creases in trousers, socks that have soft toes, underwear that is folded, and sweaters you can sniff without passing out. He's the child who always applauds the Ring Around the Collar commercials.

The opposite is the youngster who neither desires what is in his closet nor what is in the dirty clothes hamper. He wants what has to be ironed. I have always said, "If I had nothing in my ironing bag but a diaper, that kid would wear a top hat and go to school dressed as the New Year."

Last year, we allowed our children to pack their own suitcases for our vacation. One wore a baseball cap and a pair of brown corduroys for an entire week. (We told everyone he had brain surgery.)

Another brought one coat . . . and old army jacket belonging to his father. (He looked like a deserter from

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the other side.) The other one packed one pair of shoes . . a red-white-and-blue pair of sneakers with stars. The only time he didn't look out of place was under a basket in a coliseum.

Last week, all three of my children looked worse than usual as they headed for the door. "Why do all of you look so rotten today?" I asked. "Are you in a school play or something?"

"No, we're having our class pictures taken."

It figures.

Who killed apple pie?

It's a frightening feeling to wake up one morning and discover that while you were asleep you went out of style.

That's what happened to millions of housewives, who one day looked into their mirrors and said "I do not feel fulfilled putting toilet seats down all day."

Women were sick of pushing buttons, besides, the buttons were pushing back. There was a housewife in Michigan who was vacuuming her carpet one morning and

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leaned over to pick an object off the floor. Her hair was pulled into the machine by the underside brush roller, causing her to fall on top of the vacuum and sustain electrical shock to the left side of her head.

They no longer brought the theory, advanced by a British Medical Association, that doing housework was the secret to female longevity and that all that exercise would prolong life.

As I was on my knees one afternoon, hoisting the bunk beds on my back and trying to put the slats back into the grooves, my husband asked, "What are you doing down there?"

"Prolonging my life," I said dryly.

What I always wanted to do was run away from home. You all know the feeling. You diet for two weeks and gain three pounds. You break your bottom to get to a White Sale only to discover that all they have left are double top sheets, single contour bottom and King pillowcases.

Your best friend (whom you have always trusted) calls and tells you she just found out how to bake bread.

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Some wise guy just wrote "HELP" in the dust on the draperies.

You pick up a movie magazine in the supermarket with headline reading JACKIE ONASSIS' SPENDING HABITS SUGGEST MENTAL DISORDER and realize you've had the same disorder for years.

The supermarket just discontinued your silverware pattern and you spend forty minutes ironing a linen dress and it doesn't fit you anymore.

Then one day in a leading magazine, I saw a story called, "Today's Women on the Go."

At the top of the article was a picture of a well-stacked blonde at construction site with a group of men around her while she reads blueprints to them. I noted her shoes were coordinated with her Gucci yellow hard hat.

The second picture showed her in a pair of flowing pajamas standing over the stove while her husband tossed the salad and her children lovingly set the table.

It made me want to spit up.

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I wanted to be "on the go." (I was half-gone already.) Imagine! Every morning going off to carpetland . . . to fresh bread for lunch . . . to a phone that wasn't sticky with grape jelly . . . to perfume behind each knee that spelled madness to stock boys.

And I said to myself, "There, but for the grace of a babysitter go I."

Once I made up my mind, I interviewed sitters for six months. It's depressing when you realize no one wants to be paid for what you've been doing for years for nothing.

Other women, I was to discover, had the same problem. A friend of mine who is a registered nurse said she had a shattering experience. She found a "gem" who was willing to sit with her children if she left explicit instructions. The first day she left the following note:

Greg gets 1 tsp of pink medicine in refrigerator at 8 A.M. and before lunch. He has impetigo, so wash your hands good with soap and water and don't let him use anyone else's glass.

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Paula has to be taken to the potty every two to three house. There's a potty seat upstairs and a small chair in Rec. Room.

Don't let dog in the chewing gum. He craves it but has to be taken to the vet to remove. He gets pills once a day (no birth control) for slight infection. Get Frank (who is in an out all day long) to hold him so he will not bite.

Take messages. Don't use toilet in utility room. It bubbles. If you have questions, call me.

When she arrived home, the door was marked with lamb's blood and there was a large quarantine sign tacked on it. The sitter had fled.

<u>Who is I. Dunno?</u>

Ever since I can remember, our home has harbored a fourth child-I. Dunno. Everyone sees him but me. All I know is, he's rotten.

"Who left the front door open?"

"I. Dunno."

"Who let the soap melt down the drain?"

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"I. Dunno."

"Who ate the banana I was saving for the cake?"

"I.Dunno."

Frankly, I. Dunno is driving me nuts.

He's lost two umbrellas, four pairs of boots and a bicycle. He has thirteen books overdue from the library, hasn't brought home a paper from school in three years and once left a thermos of milk in the car for three weeks.

The other day the phone rang. I ran from the mailbox, cut my leg, tore off a fingernail in the door and got to the phone in time to see my son hanging up. "Who was it?" I asked breathlessly. "I. Dunno. He hung up."

When I told my neighbor about it she said, "Cheer up. I've had an invisible child for years."

"What's his name?"

"Nobody."

"Is he rotten?"

"He makes Dennis the Menace look like a statue. He cracked the top of an heirloom candy dish, tears up the paper before anyone gets to read it, and once when

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I was driving the car pool, he nearly knocked me senseless with a ball bat."

"Ha!" I said bitterly, "you should have seen I. Dunno. He left thirteen light burning the other night when he went out. I don't know how much longer I can stand it." This morning at breakfast, I said to my husband,

"Who wants liver for dinner this evening?" He looked up and said "I dontcare." That can only mean one thing. I. Dunno has a brother.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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